Fortunately, the Milk

By Neil Gaiman

ME: *(searching the refrigerator)* There was only orange juice in the fridge. Nothing else that you could put on cereal, unless you think that ketchup or mayonnaise or pickle juice would be nice, which I do not.

DAD: Eat your cereal. Remember, it's Orchestra Practice this afternoon

SISTER: We can't eat our cereal. No milk.

ME: He looked like he was going to suggest that we have something for breakfast that you do not need milk for, like sausages, but then he remembered that, without milk, he couldn't have his tea.

DAD: You poor children. I will get milk . . .

INTRODUCTION

Author Neil Gaiman is a phenomenon. I'm not saying that's good. I'm not saying that's bad. I'm simply stating a fact. A fellow author recently commented that when Gaiman talks, people clap. When he coughs, they laugh. And there's no better way to introduce you to his unique storytelling style than to take you on a mystical adventure with an imaginative and creative father in Fortunately, the Milk by Neil Gaiman

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SISTER: Where have you been all this time?

DAD: I bought the milk. I walked out of the corner shop and heard something odd coming from above me. It was a noise like this: ***thummthumm***. I looked up and saw a huge silver disc hovering in the air. And the next thing I knew, I was being sucked up into the disc. Fortunately, I had put the milk into my coat pocket. The people in the disc were a bit green and rather globby and they looked very grumpy indeed.

ALIEN: As a representative of your species, we demand that you give us ownership of the whole planet. We are going to remodel it.

DAD: I jolly well won't. *(to the kids)* I noticed a large metal door with EMERGENCY EXIT DO NOT OPEN FOR ANY REASON THIS MEANS YOU! on it. I opened the door.

ALIEN: Don't do that. You'll let the space-time continuum in.

DAD: But it was too late; I had already pushed open the door. I JUMPED. Fortunately, I had kept tight hold of the milk, so when I splashed into the sea I didn't lose it.

PIRATE QUEEN: What was that? A big fish? A mermaid? Or was it a spy?

DAD: I wanted to say that I wasn't any of those things, but my mouth was full of seawater. I felt myself being hauled up onto the deck. There were a number of men and a woman on the deck, and they all looked very cross.

PIRATE QUEEN: Who be ye, landlubber? What are you doing here?

DAD: Well . . . I just set out to the corner shop for some milk for my children's breakfast and for my tea, and the next thing I knew—

PIRATE QUEEN: You dare lie to the Queen of the Pirates?

DAD: If I did not go to the corner shop to fetch the milk, then where did this milk come from? *(showing her the milk)*

PIRATE QUEEN: You're on a pirate ship now, my fine bucko. There are only two choices—you can join my pirate crew, or refuse to join and we will slit your cowardly throat and you will go to the bottom of the sea, where you will feed the fishes.

DAD: I wish that I could, but I have children. And they need their breakfast.

PIRATE QUEEN: Then you must die! Walk the plank!

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DAD: I edged out to the end of the plank. Sharks were circling. So were piranhas—

ME: Hang on. Piranhas are a freshwater fish. What were they doing in the sea?

DAD: You're right. Right. So . . . I was out at the end of the plank, facing certain death, when a rope ladder hit my shoulder . . .

STEG: QUICKLY! CLIMB UP THE ROPE LADDER!

DAD: Fortunately, the milk was pushed deep into the pocket of my coat. And I soon made it to the top of the rope ladder. I'd never been in the basket of a hot air balloon before.

STEG: I hope you don't mind me helping, but it looked like you were having problems down there.

DAD: You're a stegosaurus!

STEG: I am an inventor. I have invented the thing we are traveling in, which I call Professor Steg's Floaty-Ball-Person-Carrier.

DAD: *(to Steg)* I call it a balloon . . . *(to the kids)* He showed me his Time Machine. He was very proud of it. It was a large cardboard box with several pebbles on it, and stones stuck to the side. There was also a large, red

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button. *(to Steg)* Hang on. Those are diamonds. And sapphires. And rubies.

STEG: Actually, I call them special-shiny-clear-stones, special-shiny-bluey-stones, and, um—

DAD: Well, it was very lucky for me that you turned up when you did and rescued me. I need to get home in order to make sure my children get milk for their breakfast. *(shows him the milk)* Although I expect that one hundred and fifty million years ago you called it 'wet-white-drinky-stuff. Can you take me home?

STEG: Yes and no. Yes, I would love to take you home. Nothing would make me happier. No, I cannot take you home. My Time Machine is being temperamental. I have pressed that button many times but nothing happens.

DAD: Button? Don't you mean 'big-red-flat-pressy-thing'?

STEG: I most certainly do not. It is a button. I named it after my Aunt Button.

DAD: Can I press it? *(to the kids)* I pressed the button. The sun shot around the sky, and the balloon began to rock and lurch and zoom around like an angry fly. I held on

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to the ropes as hard as I could. Fortunately, I was still keeping tight hold of the milk in my right hand.

SISTER: Are there any ponies in this? I thought there would be ponies by now.

DAD: *(ad libbing like crazy to somehow incorporate ponies)* The machine stopped. We were hanging in the air above a grassy plain. Below me, on a number of brightly colored ponies were gathered.

PONY: You must be the man with the milk. We have heard about you, in our tales.

SISTER: I'm so glad there were ponies.

DAD: The milk! My children are breakfastless . . . *(to the kids)* And with that, Professor Steg pressed the red button with his heavily armored tail. There was a ***ZOOM***, a ***TWORP***, and a ***THANG***, and we were hurtling through the cosmic void --FLOATING above a landscape of ominous towers and castles. It was not a friendly place. Bats flew across the sky in huge flocks. There was a loud ***FLUT***!, and where the bats had been, several pallid people were now standing. The man in front had a very bald head. THEY ALL HAD SHARP TEETH.

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VAMPIRE: Ve are wumpires. Vot is this? Who are you? Answer us, or ve vill wiwisect you.

STEG: I am Professor Steg. We are on an important mission. My assistant is trying to get home to the future for breakfast."

DAD: At the word BREAKFAST all the wumpires looked very excited.

VAMPIRE: Ve have not had our breakfast. Ve normally have vigglyvorms, vith orange juice on them. Orange juice makes vorms ewen vigglier. Like vandering spaghetti. But if ve cannot eat vorms ve vill eat assistant, or ewen roast professor.

DAD: One of the wumpires took out a fork and looked me up and down in a hungry sort of way. The professor tinkered with the jewels and the string and the buttons.

STEG: I think I've got it properly fine-tuned, now. This next press should bring you back to your own time, place, and breakfast.

DAD: I pressed the red button. The hole in space opened again. And [we and] the milk came rocketing through. There was an ear-popping noise and I was floating, in a

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balloon basket. I could see our house. I could see the bicycles in the back garden. I could see the rabbit hutch.

ME: Does that mean that there is a Stegosaurus in a hot air balloon outside?

DAD: There is not. For reasons that will become apparent

SISTER: *(wistfully)* I think that there should have been some nice wumpires . . . Nice, handsome, misunderstood wumpires."

DAD: There was a familiar sort of a thumm-thumm noise, and before I had a chance to press the red button [again], we were deposited, balloon and all, on the enormous metal deck of a flying saucer, with a number of very grumpy-looking green globby people staring at us with too many eyes. They did not look pleased.

ALIEN: HaHA! You thought you had escaped us! And you were wrong! Now, you must sign the planet over to us so that we can remodel it. We will take out all the trees and put in plastic flamingoes. Also, we are going to replace the clouds with scented candles. We have been tracking your movements through time and space. Now, see what happens when I press this grundledorfer *(points to a button on the spaceship control panel).*

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DAD: It's called a button.

ALIEN: Nonsense. We named it after our brood-aunt, Nessie Grundledorfer. *(pushes the button)*

DAD: There was a ***CRACKLE***. There was a ***FIZZ***. Standing around us, in attitudes of anger and irritation, were several pirates and some wumpires.

PIRATE QUEEN: Prepare to be keelhauled, you scurvy dogs.

VAMPIRE: Ve vants those willains and warmints wiolently vound up.

DAD: The aliens looked at each other. One of them pressed the grundledorfer. The wumpires and pirates were gone. It was at that moment that a voice louder than anything I have ever heard said

POLICE: GALACTIC POLICE. DO NOT MOVE.

DAD: There were red and blue flashing lights and about half a dozen uniformed dinosaurs, holding unmistakably large and extremely serious weapons. They pointed their weapons at the green globby aliens.

POLICE: You are charged with breaking into people's planets and redecorating them. And then with running away and doing it again somewhere else, over and over.

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You have committed crimes against the inhabitants of eighteen planets, and crimes against good taste.

DADThe Tyrannosaurus handcuffed all the green globby people together with something that looked a lot more like pink string-in-a-can than it looked like handcuffs, which was a good thing because they probably didn't have hands and they definitely didn't have wrists. The last I saw of any of them, the whole inside of the saucer was fading into light so bright I had to close my eyes and look away. And then I was standing at the back door of our house, none the worse for wear. So I came in. And here I am . . .

ME: That was what my dad said. I looked around the kitchen. At the calendar on the wall with the hot air balloons on it. At my dinosaur models and my sister's ponies, at my sister's vampire books.

SISTER: You know we don't believe any of this.

ME: Especially not how you saved the world from being remodeled. Or the pirates. Not. Any. Of. It.

DAD: *(shrugging)* Suit yourselves. But it was all true. And I can prove it. Here's the MILK!

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